Civic Theory and Practice
Activities and ideas for activists

Danielle Allen's speech norms

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It is common–and a good idea–to develop norms for speech within a group, such as a classroom or a community association.

In Talking to Strangers (2004), political philosopher Danielle Allen develops a theory of speech that is helpful in a democracy, such as the United States. On pp. 157-8, she offers a list of principles for speakers and for listeners, based on this theory. These are principles for how people ought to talk in public, not specific norms that should apply in a class or an organization. However, you can review her list of general principles (see below) and ask whether and how you would make them into norms or rules for your actual group.

In order to generate trust, a speaker should

— aim to convince 100 percent of her audience; if she finds herself considering rather how to carry a majority, she is acting in a fashion that over the long term will undermine democracy;
— test herself by speaking to minority constituents whose votes she does not need;
— once she has found the limits of her ability to persuade, she should think also about how to ameliorate the remaining disagreement and distrust;
— "separate the people from the problem" by (i) developing external standards and universal principles for assessing problems and (ii) recognizing that dealing with the people means engaging with specific features of their subjective situation;
— be precise about which emotions are at stake in a particular conversation;
— seek to transform conditions of utility into experiences of goodwill;
— recognize that reciprocity is established over time and that enough trust has to be generated to allow this process to proceed;
— recognize that the most powerful tool for generating trust is the capacity to prove that she is willing to make sacrifices even for the strangers in her polity;
— be aware too that she is trustworthy only if she can point to a *habit* of making sacrifices for strangers and not merely to a single instance;[19]
— recognize that where there is no trust, a great sacrifice will be necessary to sow the first seeds of trust, which can develop only over time through repeated interactions in which citizens have opportunities to test each other;
— give her audience opportunities for judging (accepting or rejecting) her arguments;
— be willing to have any member of the polity respond to her arguments.

In order to prepare the way for the generation of trust, a listener should

— separate a speaker's claims about facts from the principles on which her conclusions are based; assess both;
— ask whether a speaker has a history of making pragmatically correct decisions;
— ask who is sacrificing for whom, whether the sacrifices are voluntary, and honored; whether they can and will be reciprocated;
— ask whether the speaker has spoken as a friend;
— insist on opportunities to judge political arguments;
— judge.

Related theory

Deliberative democracy

A deliberative democracy is a system in which people discuss before they make decisions. In order for the system to be democratic, people must have reasonably equal power over decisions, which usually means that they each have one vote (although small groups may not using voting). In order for their discussions to qualify as deliberative, ... Continue reading →

Ideology

The “word” ideology is used at least three different ways in different intellectual communities or traditions: It can mean the politically relevant opinions that any person holds. In that sense, we all have ideologies, even if we happen to hold few political opinions. It can mean relatively organized, coherent, and recognizable systems of political belief, … Continue reading →

Jürgen Habermas

Jürgen Habermas (1929-) is a German philosopher and sociologist, often seen as the leader of the intellectual movement called the “Frankfurt School” in its second generation, when he helped to shift it away from Marxism. He is often presented as a proponent and theorist of deliberative democracy, although he does not endorse all of the … Continue reading →

Motivated reasoning

People tend to prefer, recall, and emphasize facts that support ideas they already hold, and they doubt or marginalize facts that complicate or challenge those ideas. For example, as people obtain more education, their opinions of climate change correlate more with their political ideology. Conservatives become less likely to believe in climate change, and liberals … Continue reading →

Propaganda

It is possible to deploy money, talent, expertise, fame, and/or ownership of communications media (such as a television network) to influence public opinion. All such examples of well-resourced persuasive communication could be defined as propaganda, regardless of quality or purpose. Some definitions of the word build in negative connotations, so that a helpful mass message … Continue reading →

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